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What the Standard Doesn’t Say

A Census of Hand-Lettered Signage’s Recurrence After the Approved Signage Standard’s Rollout

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The problem

Facilities’ Approved Signage Standard replaced ad hoc notices across lifts, kitchens, and noticeboards with eleven laminated templates. What did the improvised signs say that the template list doesn’t, and how long did a cleared site stay that way?

What we set out to test

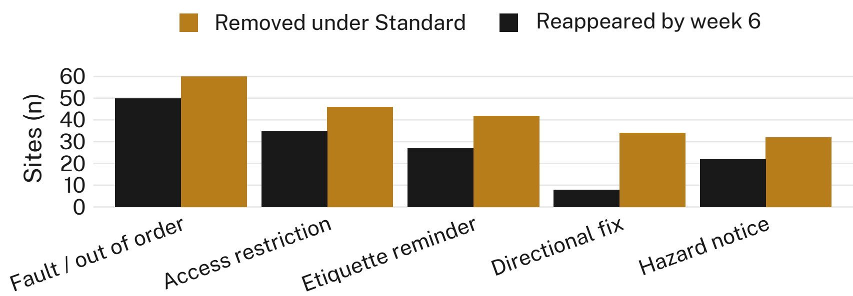
- Catalogue the functions ad hoc signage served before removal
- Cross-check removed sites against the Standard’s eleven-template list
- Track how many sites carried a new hand-lettered sign within six weeks of removal

Approach

- $n = 214$ removal sites, 11 buildings · photographed at removal, then at weeks 2, 4, and 6
- Two coders blind to building sorted signs into a five-category function taxonomy ($\kappa = 0.77$)
- Recurrence window and coding protocol pre-registered with the Adaptive Metrics Lab; neither adjusted post hoc

Findings

A hand-lettered sign reappeared at 142 of 214 sites within six weeks (66%), in every function category except directional fixes — the one the Standard’s own templates already cover.



Fault/out-of-order and access-restriction notices recurred fastest — 83% and 76% back by week six — against 24% for directional fixes, the only category the Standard’s templates also address (3 Mar – 14 Apr 2026, $n = 214$ sites).

Implications

The eleven templates cover routine wayfinding. None covers a fault already reported, an access rule that changes weekly, an unlisted hazard, or a kitchen-etiquette dispute — and recurrence tracked that gap almost exactly, staying low only where a template already existed. Next: pilot a “reported fault” template at the two highest-recurrence buildings and re-run the six-week count.

Selected references

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2. Star, S. L., & Griesemer, J. R. (1989). Institutional ecology, ‘translations’ and boundary objects: Amateurs and professionals in Berkeley’s Museum of Vertebrate Zoology, 1907–39. *Social Studies of Science, 19*(3), 387–420. doi:10.1177/030631289019003001
3. Gasser, L. (1986). The integration of computing and routine work. *ACM Transactions on Information Systems, 4*(3), 205–225. doi:10.1145/214427.214429
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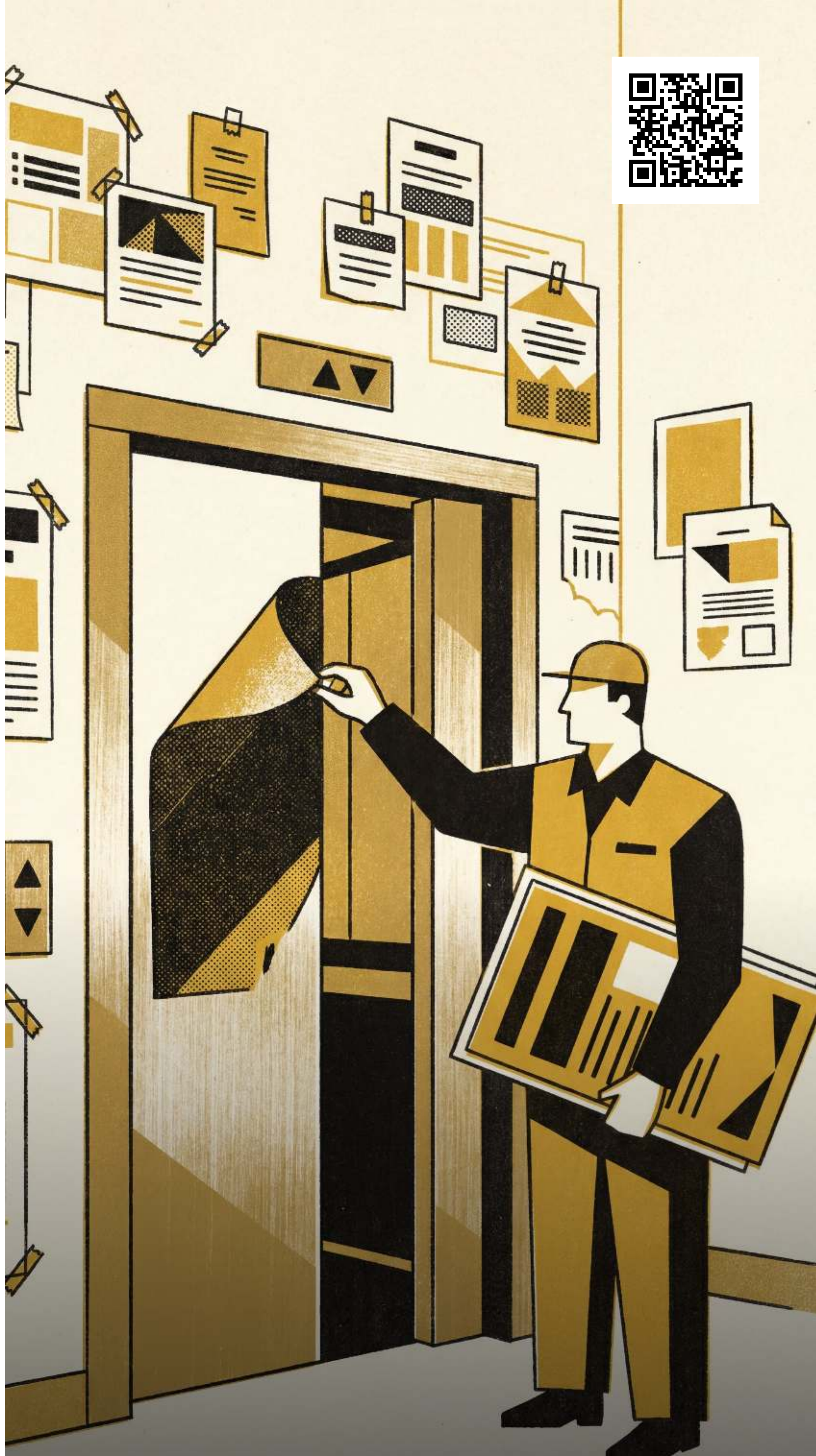
Site photographs de-identified; no handwriting attributable beyond function category. Thresholds pre-registered; none adjusted.



“Two-thirds of the signs Facilities took down were back within six weeks.”

142 of 214 removal sites carried a new hand-lettered notice by week six.